

COUNTDOWN BEGINS
PM Rajiv Gandhi minutes before his assassination

born as a riddle four decades earlier, and spent time germinating while India toggled between cynical denialism and blissful ignorance. A rigged state election in 1987 blew the cover, and inaugurated one of the most serious armed insurgencies India has seen.

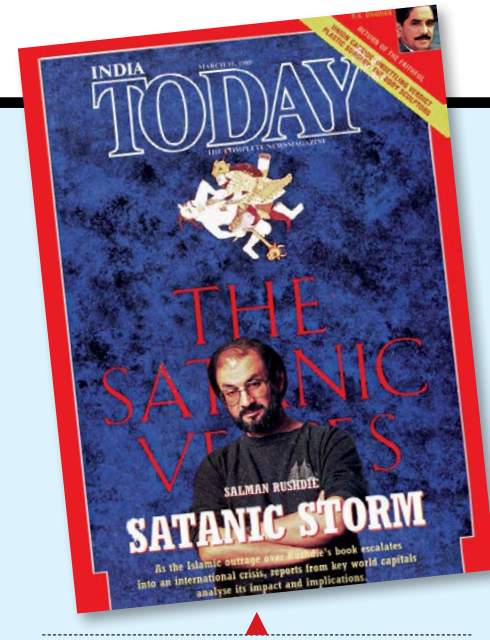
Roop Kanwar's sati, September 4, 1987: It only took a village in Rajasthan to turn India's clock back by centuries. An 18-year-old, widowed after eight months, went up on her husband's pyre, hundreds watched. Thousands still approve of the act—to the point of veneration.

AMIDST EVENTS ON A GRANDER SCALE, AN UNFORESEEN BIT OF RECKONING AWAITED INDIA IN ITS INNARDS: THE PRE-MODERN SPECTRE OF SATI GOT A NEW LIFE

Rajiv Gandhi assassination, May 21, 1991: The IPKF misadventure was to exact its last, grisly toll in Tamil Nadu's Sriperumbudur, as an LTTE suicide-bomber became the former PM's cruel tryst with destiny.

Babri Masjid demolition, December 6, 1992: Over the years, its proponents gamed the law cannily and eventually subsumed it. But they began by cocking a snook at it. Even the Ayodhya verdict of 2019, which ceded the land to the temple, called it an "egregious" violation.

Babri-linked riots/Bombay blasts, 1990-93: The 16th century mosque demolished in Ayodhya was only a symbol for a long-drawn, sanguinary rite of revanchism, with thousands of sacrificial lambs across India. The riposte from the don Dawood Ibrahim left scars that lingered for decades to come. ■



Satanic Storm
Mar. 15, 1989

"On television [Salman] Rushdie's haunting face with the heavy-lidded eyes and unevenly folded lips dominate. State of art media brings images which are archaic, reminiscent of the battlefields of the Holy Wars. The smell of the smoke from the burning books is almost palpable: the angry eyes and raised fists of mobs in Bradford and Teheran electrify."